

'A very serious affair,' said Poirot: 'the death of Madame Kettering.'

'Let me see,' M. Papopolous looked innocently up at the ceiling, 'that was the lady who died on the Blue Train, was it not? I saw a mention of it in the papers, but there was no suggestion of foul play.'

'In the interests of justice,' said Poirot, 'it was thought best to suppress that fact.'

There was a pause.

'And in what way can I assist you, M. Poirot?' asked the dealer politely.

'*Voilà*,' said Poirot, 'I shall come to the point.' He took from his pocket the same box that he had displayed at Cannes, and opening it, he took out the rubies and pushed them across the table to Papopolous.

Although Poirot was watching him narrowly, not a muscle of the old man's face moved. He took up the jewels and examined them with a kind of detached interest, then he looked across at the detective inquiringly:

'Superb, are they not?' asked Poirot.

'Quite excellent,' said M. Papopolous.

'How much should you say they are worth?'

The Greek's face quivered a little.

'Is it really necessary to tell you, M. Poirot?' he asked.

'You are shrewd, M. Papopolous. No, it is not. They are not, for instance, worth five hundred thousand dollars.'

Papopolous laughed, and Poirot joined with him.

'As an imitation,' said Papopolous, handing them back to Poirot, 'they are, as I said, quite excellent. Would it be indiscreet to ask, M. Poirot, where you came across them?'

'Not at all,' said Poirot; 'I have no objection to telling an old friend like yourself. They were in the possession of the Comte de la Roche.'

M. Papopolous' eyebrows lifted themselves eloquently.

'In-deed,' he murmured.

Poirot leant forward and assumed his most innocent and beguiling air.

'M. Papopolous,' he said, 'I am going to lay my cards upon the table. The original of these jewels was stolen from Madame Kettering on the Blue Train. Now I will say to you first this: *I am not concerned with the recovery of these jewels. That is the affair of the police.* I am working not for the police but for M. Van Aldin. I want to lay hands on the man who killed Madame Kettering.

I am interested in the jewels only in so far as they may lead me to the man. You understand?'

The last two words were uttered with great significance. M. Papopolous, his face quite unmoved, said quietly:

'Go on.'

'It seems to me probable, Monsieur, that the jewels will change hands in Nice—may already have done so.'

'Ah!' said M. Papopolous.

He sipped his coffee reflectively, and looked a shade more noble and patriarchal than usual.

'I say to myself,' continued Poirot, with animation, 'what good fortune! My old friend, M. Papopolous, is in Nice. He will aid me.'

'And how do you think I can aid you?' inquired M. Papopolous coldly.

'I said to myself, without doubt M. Papopolous is in Nice on business.'

'Not at all,' said M. Papopolous, 'I am here for my health—by the doctor's orders.'

He coughed hollowly.

'I am desolated to hear it,' replied Poirot, with somewhat insincere sympathy.

'But to continue. When a Russian Grand Duke, an Austrian Archduchess, or an Italian Prince wish to dispose of their family jewels—to whom do they go? To M. Papopolous, is it not? He who is famous all over the world for the discretion with which he arranges these things.'

The other bowed.

'You flatter me.'

'It is a great thing, discretion,' mused Poirot, and was rewarded by the fleeting smile which passed across the Greek's face. 'I, too, can be discreet.'

The eyes of the two men met.

Then Poirot went on speaking very slowly, and obviously picking his words with care.

'I say to myself, this: if these jewels have changed hands in Nice, M. Papopolous would have heard of it. He has knowledge of all that passes in the jewel world.'

'Ah!' said M. Papopolous, and helped himself to a *croissant*.

'The police, you understand,' said M. Poirot, 'do not enter into the matter. It is a personal affair.'

'One hears rumours,' admitted M. Papopolous cautiously.

'Such as?' prompted Poirot.

'Is there any reason why I should pass them on?'

'Yes,' said Poirot, 'I think there is. You may remember, M. Papopolous, that seventeen years ago there was a certain article in your hands, left there as security by a very—er—Prominent Person. It was in your keeping and it unaccountably disappeared. You were, if I may use the English expression, in the soup.'

His eyes came gently round to the girl. She had pushed her cup and plate aside, and with both elbows on the table and her chin resting on her hands was listening eagerly. Still keeping an eye on her he went on:

'I am in Paris at the time. You send for me. You place yourself in my hands. If I restore to you that—article, you say I shall earn your undying gratitude. *Eh bien*! I did restore it to you.'

Along sigh came from M. Papopolous.

'It was the most unpleasant moment of my career,' he murmured.

'Seventeen years is a long time,' said Poirot thoughtfully, 'but I believe that I am right in saying, Monsieur, that your race does not forget.'

'A Greek?' murmured Papopolous, with an ironical smile.

'It was not as a Greek I meant,' said Poirot.

There was a silence, and then the old man drew himself up proudly.

'You are right, M. Poirot,' he said quietly. 'I am a Jew. And, as you say, our race does not forget.'

'You will aid me then?'

'As regards the jewels, Monsieur, I can do nothing.'

The old man, as Poirot had done just now, picked his words carefully.

'I know nothing. I have heard nothing. But I can perhaps do you a good turn—that is, if you are interested in racing.'

'Under certain circumstances I might be,' said Poirot, eyeing him steadily.

'There is a horse running at Longchamps that would, I think, repay attention. I cannot say for certain, you understand; this news passed through so many hands.'

He stopped, fixing Poirot with his eye, as though to make sure that the latter was comprehending him.

'Perfectly, perfectly,' said Poirot, nodding.

Chapter 22

M. Papopolous Breakfasts

M. Papopolous was at breakfast. Opposite him sat his daughter, Zia. There was a knock at the sitting-room door, and a chasseur entered with a card which he brought to Mr Papopolous. The latter scrutinized it, raised his eyebrows, and passed it over to his daughter.

'Ah!' said M. Papopolous, scratching his left ear thoughtfully, 'Hercule Poirot. I wonder now.'

Father and daughter looked at each other.

'I saw him yesterday at the tennis,' said M. Papopolous. 'Zia, I hardly like this.'

'He was very useful to you once,' his daughter reminded him.

'That is true,' acknowledged M. Papopolous; 'also he has retired from active work, so I hear.'

These interchanges between father and daughter had passed in their own language. Now M. Papopolous turned to the chasseur and said in French:

'*Faites monter ce monsieur*.'

A few minutes later Hercule Poirot, exquisitely attired, and swinging a cane with a jaunty air, entered the room.

'My dear M. Papopolous.'

'My dear M. Poirot.'

'And Mademoiselle Zia.' Poirot swept her a low bow.

'You will excuse us going on with our breakfast,' said M. Papopolous, pouring himself out another cup of coffee. 'Your call is—ahem!—a little early.'

'It is scandalous,' said Poirot, 'but see you, I am pressed.'

'Ah!' murmured M. Papopolous, 'you are on an affair then?'

'The name of the horse,' said M. Papopolous, leaning back and joining the tips of his fingers together, 'is the Marquis. I think, but I am not sure, that it is an English horse, eh, Zia?'

'I think so too,' said the girl.

Poirot got up briskly.

'I thank you, Monsieur,' he said. 'It is a great thing to have what the English call a tip from the stable. Au revoir, Monsieur, and many thanks.'

He turned to the girl.

'Au revoir, Mademoiselle Zia. It seems to me but yesterday that I saw you in Paris. One would say that two years had passed at most.'

'There is a difference between sixteen and thirty-three,' said Zia ruefully.

'Not in your case,' declared Poirot gallantly. 'You and your father will perhaps dine with me one night.'

'We shall be delighted,' replied Zia.

'Then we will arrange it,' declared Poirot, 'and now—*je me salue*.'

Poirot walked along the street humming a little tune to himself. He twirled his stick with a jaunty air, once or twice he smiled to himself quietly. He turned into the first Bureau de Poste he came to and sent off a telegram. He took some time in wording it, but it was in code and he had to call upon his memory. It purported to deal with a missing scarf-pin, and was addressed to Inspector Japp, Scotland Yard.

Decoded, it was short and to the point. '*Write me everything known about man whose soubriquet is the Marquis.*'

‘Well,’ said Van Aldin, ‘go ahead. What is this little idea?’

Poirot paused for a moment and then he said:

‘I will call upon you at your hotel at eleven o’clock to-morrow morning. Until then, say nothing to any one.’

'Yes, but what is inside?' demanded Van Aldin impatiently.

Poirot unwrapped the brown paper and disclosed a square cardboard box. He looked round him.

'It is a good moment,' he said quietly. 'All eyes are on the tennis. Look, Monsieur!'

He lifted the lid of the box for the fraction of a second. An exclamation of utter astonishment came from the millionaire. His face turned as white as chalk.

'My God!' he breathed, 'the rubies.'

He sat for a minute as though dazed. Poirot restored the box to his pocket and beamed placidly. Then suddenly the millionaire seemed to come out of his trance; he leaned across to Poirot and wrung his hand so heartily that the little man winced with pain.

'This is great,' said Van Aldin. 'Great! You are the goods, M. Poirot. Once and for all, you are the goods.'

'It is nothing,' said Poirot modestly. 'Order, method, being prepared for eventualities beforehand—that is all there is to it.'

'And now, I suppose, the Comte de la Roche has been arrested?' continued Van Aldin eagerly.

'No,' said Poirot.

A look of utter astonishment came over Van Aldin's face.

'But why? What more do you want?'

'The Comte's alibi is still unshaken.'

'But that is nonsense.'

'Yes,' said Poirot; 'I rather think it is nonsense, but unfortunately we have to prove it so.'

'In the meantime he will slip through your fingers.'

Poirot shook his head very energetically.

'No,' he said, 'he will not do that. The one thing the Comte cannot afford to sacrifice is his social position. At all costs he must stop and brazen it out.'

Van Aldin was still dissatisfied.

'But I don't see—'

Poirot raised a hand. 'Grant me a little moment, Monsieur. Me, I have a little idea. Many people have mocked themselves at the little ideas of Hercule Poirot—and they have been wrong.'

Chapter 23

A New Theory

IT was exactly eleven o'clock when Poirot presented himself at Van Aldin's hotel. He found the millionaire alone.

'You are punctual, M. Poirot,' he said, with a smile, as he rose to greet the detective.

'I am always punctual,' said Poirot. 'The exactitude—always do I observe it. Without order and method—'

He broke off. 'Ah, but it is possible that I have said these things to you before. Let us come at once to the object of my visit.'

'Your little idea?'

'Yes, my little idea.' Poirot smiled.

'First of all, Monsieur. I should like to interview once more the maid, Ada Mason. She is here?'

'Yes, she's here.'

'Ah!'

Van Aldin looked at him curiously. He rang the bell, and a messenger was dispatched to find Mason.

Poirot greeted her with his usual politeness, which was never without effect on that particular class.

'Good afternoon, Mademoiselle,' he said cheerfully. 'Be seated, will you not, if Monsieur permits.'

'Yes, yes, sit down, my girl,' said Van Aldin.

'Thank you, sir,' said Mason primly, and she sat down on the extreme edge of a chair. She looked bonier and more acid than ever.

'I have come to ask you yet more questions,' said Poirot. 'We must get to the bottom of this affair. Always I return to the question of the man in the

train. You have been shown the Comte de la Roche. You say that it is possible he was the man, but you are not sure.'

'As I told you, sir, I never saw the gentleman's face. That is what makes it so difficult.'

Poirot beamed and nodded.

'Precisely, exactly. I comprehend well the difficulty. Now, Mademoiselle, you have been in the service of Madame Kettering two months, you say. During that time, how often did you see your master?'

Mason reflected a minute or two, and then said:

'Only twice, sir.'

'And was that near to, or far away?'

'Well once, sir, he came to Curzon Street. I was upstairs, and I looked over the banisters and saw him in the hall below. I was a bit curious like, you understand, knowing the way things—er—were.' Mason finished up with her discreet cough.

'And the other time?'

'I was in the Park, sir, with Annie—one of the housemaids, sir, and she pointed out the master to me walking with a foreign lady.'

Again Poirot nodded.

'Now listen, Mason, this man whom you saw in the carriage talking to your mistress at the Gare de Lyon, how do you know it was not your master?'

'The master, sir? Oh, I don't think it could have been.'

'But you are not sure,' Poirot persisted.

'Well—I never thought of it, sir.'

Mason was clearly upset at the idea.

'You have heard that your master was also on the train. What more natural than that it should be he who came along the corridor.'

'But the gentleman who was talking to the mistress must have come from outside, sir. He was dressed for the street. In an overcoat and soft hat.'

'Just so, Mademoiselle, but reflect a minute. The train has just arrived at the Gare de Lyon. Many of the passengers promenade themselves upon the quay. Your mistress was about to do so, and for that purpose had doubtless put on her fur coat, eh?'

'Yes, sir,' agreed Mason.

d'Instruction. The day after that, during his absence, the Villa Marina was searched by the police.'

'Well,' said Van Aldin, 'did they find anything? I bet they didn't.'

Poirot made him a little bow.

'Your acumen is not at fault, M. Van Aldin. They found nothing of an incriminating nature. It was not to be expected that they would. The Comte de la Roche, as your expressive idiom has it, was not born on the preceding day. He is an astute gentleman with great experience.'

'Well, go on,' growled Van Aldin.

'It may be, of course, that the Comte had nothing of a compromising nature to conceal. But we must not neglect the possibility. If, then, he has something to conceal, where is it? Not in his house—the police searched thoroughly. Not on his person, for he knows that he is liable to arrest at any minute. There remains—his car. As I say, he was under surveillance. He was followed on that day to Monte Carlo. From there he went by road to Mentone, driving himself. His car is a very powerful one, it outdistanced his pursuers, and for about a quarter of an hour they completely lost sight of him.'

'And during that time you think he concealed something by the roadside?' asked Van Aldin, keenly interested.

'By the roadside, no. *Ça n'est pas pratique*. But listen now—me, I have made a little suggestion to M. Carrège. He is graciously pleased to approve of it. In each Bureau de Poste in the neighbourhood it has been seen to that there is some one who knows the Comte de la Roche by sight. Because, you see, Monsieur, the best way of hiding a thing is by sending it away by the post.'

'Well?' demanded Van Aldin; his face was keenly alight with interest and expectation.

'Well—*voilà*! With a dramatic flourish Poirot drew out from his pocket a loosely wrapped brown paper package from which the string had been removed.

'During that quarter of an hour's interval, our good gentleman mailed this.'

'The address?' asked the other sharply.

Poirot nodded his head.

'Might have told us something, but unfortunately it does not. The package was addressed to one of these little newspaper shops in Paris where letters and parcels are kept until called for on payment of a small commission.'

'Do not enrage yourself, I beg of you. Every one has his own methods. Me, I have always found it a delightful and pleasing idea to combine business and pleasure together.'

He glanced at the other two. They were deep in conversation, absorbed in each other. Poirot nodded his head in satisfaction, and then leant towards the millionaire, lowering his voice as he did so.

'It is not only for pleasure that I am here, M. Van Aldin. Observe just opposite us that tall old man—the one with the yellow face and the venerable beard.'

'Well, what of him?'

'That,' Poirot said, 'is M. Papopolous.'

'A Greek, eh?'

'As you say—a Greek. He is a dealer in antiques of world-wide reputation. He has a small shop in Paris, and he is suspected by the police of being something more.'

'What?'

'A receiver of stolen goods, especially jewels. There is nothing as to the re-cutting and re-setting of gems that he does not know. He deals with the highest in Europe and with the lowest of the underworld.'

Van Aldin was looking at Poirot with suddenly awakened attention.

'Well?' he demanded, a new note in his voice.

'I ask myself,' said Poirot, 'I, Hercule Poirot'—he thumped himself dramatically on the chest—'ask myself *why* is M. Papopolous suddenly come to Nice?'

Van Aldin was impressed. For a moment he had doubted Poirot and suspected the little man of being past his job, a *poseur* only. Now, in a moment, he switched back to his original opinion. He looked straight at the little detective.

'I must apologize to you, M. Poirot.'

Poirot waved the apology aside with an extravagant gesture.

'Bah!' he cried, 'all that is of no importance. Now listen, M. Van Aldin; I have news for you.'

The millionaire looked sharply at him, all his interest aroused.

Poirot nodded.

'It is as I say. You will be interested. As you know, M. Van Aldin, the Comte de la Roche has been under surveillance ever since his interview with the juge

'Your master, then, does the same. The train is heaved, but outside in the station it is cold. He puts on his overcoat and his hat and he walks along beside the train, and looking up at the lighted windows he suddenly sees Madame Kettering. Until then he has had no idea that she was on the train. Naturally, he mounts the carriage and goes to her compartment. She gives an exclamation of surprise at seeing him and quickly shuts the door between the two compartments since it is possible that their conversation may be of a private nature.'

He leaned back in his chair and watched the suggestion slowly take effect. No one knew better than Hercule Poirot that the class to which Mason belongs cannot be hurried. He must give her time to get rid of her own preconceived ideas. At the end of three minutes she spoke:

'Well, of course, sir, it might be so. I never thought of it that way. The master is tall and dark, and just about that build. It was seeing the hat and coat that made me say it was a gentleman from outside. Yes, it might have been the master. I would not like to say either way, I am sure.'

'Thank you very much, Mademoiselle. I shall not require you any further. Ah, just one thing more.' He took from his pocket the cigarette case he had already shown to Katherine. 'Is that your mistress's case?' he said to Mason.

'No, sir, it is not the mistress's—at least—'

She looked suddenly startled. An idea was clearly working its way to the forefront of her mind.

'Yes,' said Poirot encouragingly.

'I think, sir—I can't be sure, but I think—it is a case that the mistress bought to give to the master.'

'Ah,' said Poirot in a non-committal manner.

'But whether she ever did give it to him or not, I can't say, of course.'

'Precisely,' said Poirot, 'precisely. That is all, I think, Mademoiselle. I wish you good afternoon.'

Ada Mason retired discreetly, closing the door noiselessly behind her.

Poirot looked across at Van Aldin, a faint smile upon his face. The millionaire looked thunderstruck.

'You think—you think it was Derek?' he queried, 'but—everything points the other way. Why, the Count has actually been caught redhanded with the jewels on him.'

'No.'

'But you told me—'

'What did I tell you?'

'That story about the jewels. You showed them to me.'

'No.'

Van Aldin stared at him.

'You mean to say you didn't show them to me.'

'No.'

'Yesterday—at the tennis?'

'No.'

'Are you crazy, M. Poirot, or am I?'

'Neither of us is crazy,' said the detective. 'You ask me a question; I answer it.'

You say have I not shown you the jewels yesterday? I reply—no. What I showed you, M. Van Aldin, was a first-class imitation, hardly to be distinguished except by an expert from the real ones.'

'No, that is not mine,' Katherine said.

'Ah, a thousand apologies. It was doubtless Madame's own. 'K,' of course, stands for Kettering. We were doubtful, because she had another cigarette case in her bag, and it seemed odd that she should have two.' He turned to Derek suddenly. 'You do not know, I suppose, whether this was your wife's case or not?'

Derek seemed momentarily taken aback. He stammered a little in his reply:

'I—I don't know. I suppose so.'

'It is not yours by any chance?'

'Certainly not. If it were mine it would hardly have been in my wife's possession.'

Poirot looked more ingenuous and childlike than ever.

'I thought perhaps you might have dropped it when you were in your wife's compartment,' he explained guilelessly.

'I never was there. I have already told the police that a dozen times.'

'A thousand pardons,' said Poirot, with his most apologetic air. 'It was Mademoiselle here who mentioned having seen you going in.'

He stopped with an air of embarrassment.

Katherine looked at Derek. His face had gone rather white, but perhaps that was her fancy. His laugh, when it came, was natural enough.

'You made a mistake, Miss Grey,' he said easily. 'From what the police have told me, I gather that my own compartment was only a door or two away from that of my wife's—though I never suspected the fact at the time. You must have seen me going into my own compartment.' He got up quickly as he saw Van Aldin and Knighton approaching.

'I'm going to leave you now,' he announced. 'I can't stand my father-in-law at any price.'

Van Aldin greeted Katherine very courteously, but was clearly in a bad humour.

'You seem fond of watching tennis, M. Poirot,' he growled.

'It is a pleasure to me, yes,' cited Poirot placidly.

'It is as well you are in France,' said Van Aldin. 'We are made of sterner stuff in the States. Business comes before pleasure there.'

Poirot did not take offence; indeed, he smiled gently and confidently at the irate millionaire.